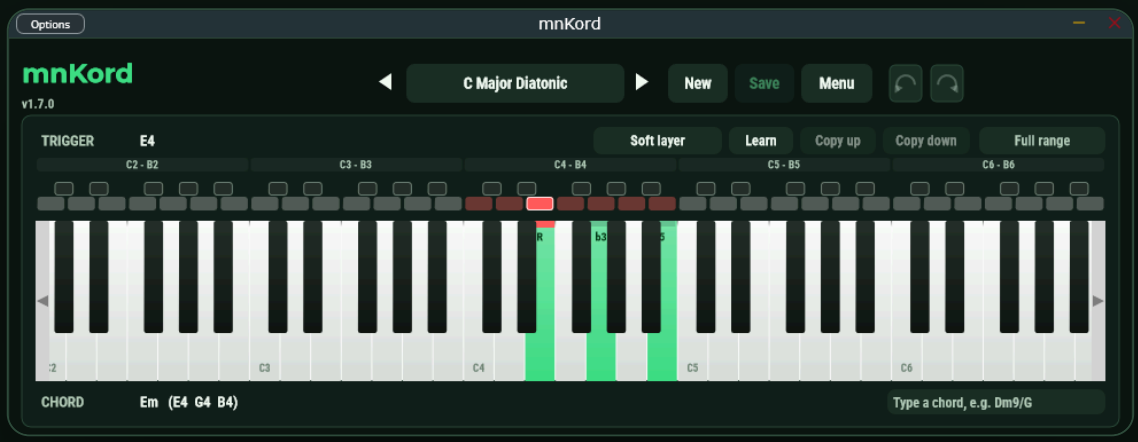
mnKord

User guide

One key. A whole chord.



Version 1.7.0

Vibecoded by **Miklós Németh**

github.com/miklosnemeth/mnkord · Free software under the AGPL-3.0

mnKord is a MIDI effect: you play one key, and it sends a whole chord. It does not make sound by itself. Put it in front of a synth, and the synth plays the chords.

```
MIDI keyboard  ->  mnKord  ->  synth / instrument
   (one key)      (maps)         (plays the chord)
```

Install

Windows: run `mnKord-<version>-win-x64-setup.exe`. It puts the plugin (VST3) into `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\MNAudio\` (a folder of its own inside the standard VST3 folder, which DAWs scan). Rescan the plugins in your DAW if it does not show up. The Standalone program is not part of the installer.

The user guide (PDF) and the licenses are installed into `C:\Program Files\MNAudio\mnKord`, with shortcuts in the Start menu. Installing a newer version over an old one works: Setup shows the version it found ("Upgrade: v1.2.0 -> v1.3.0"), asks before going back to an older one, and asks you to close your DAW if it has mnKord loaded.

To remove it, use *Settings → Apps → mnKord → Uninstall*. Your presets (see below) are kept.

Use it in a DAW

1. Create an **instrument track** and add **mnKord** to it. (mnKord is a VST3 *instrument* so that hosts let it receive MIDI and pass MIDI on. Some DAWs show it among the instruments.)
2. Put the synth that should play the chords **after** mnKord on the same track (or route mnKord's MIDI output to the synth's track). How this is done depends on the DAW: look for "MIDI output" or "plugin chain".
3. Play your keyboard. A key that has a chord in the current preset plays that chord. A key without a mapping plays nothing, and every other kind of MIDI (pitch bend, modulation, sustain pedal, ...) passes through to the synth unchanged.

The window

Area	What it is
Header	The mnKord title with the plugin's version under it, the preset name with **<** **>** arrows, **New**, **Save**, **Menu** button, and **Undo / Redo**. A dot at the left of the name means the preset has unsaved changes.
TRIGGER row	The selected trigger key, the layer menu, **Learn**, **Copy up / down** and the scale button. Under it, a strip shows the octaves.
TRIGGER lane	Small markers above the keys, one per key, in line with it. A key that has a chord is marked red, the selected one is lit, and a key you play on your controller glows.
Keyboard	The notes of the selected chord, in green. The chord's trigger key has a red band at its top, and the notes that sound are marked as you play.
CHORD row	Under the keyboard: the chord's name and notes, and a field to type a chord symbol (`Dm9/G`, `Bbmaj7`, `C6/9`, ...) that replaces the selected chord.

The window can be made wider (848 to 1600 pixels) where the DAW lets you resize a plugin window; the keys get wider.



The mnKord window

Make a chord

1. Click a marker in the **TRIGGER** lane, above the key that should play the chord. It is selected.
2. Click keys on the keyboard to add or remove notes of its chord.

Faster ways:

- **Right-click a TRIGGER marker** for chord templates (triads and sevenths). A template that would leave the selected scale is greyed out. The menu also has *Octave up / down*, *Clear chord* and *Fit to scale*.
- **Type a chord symbol** in the field under the keyboard and press Enter.
- **Right-click a key** of the keyboard to invert the chord up or down.
- **Learn:** press **Learn** and play a key on your controller. It selects that key's mapping (or creates it).



Chord templates: right-click a TRIGGER marker

Copy a chord set to another octave

Click an octave in the strip above the TRIGGER lane, then **Copy up** or **Copy down**. It copies that octave's chords one octave higher or lower.

Scale

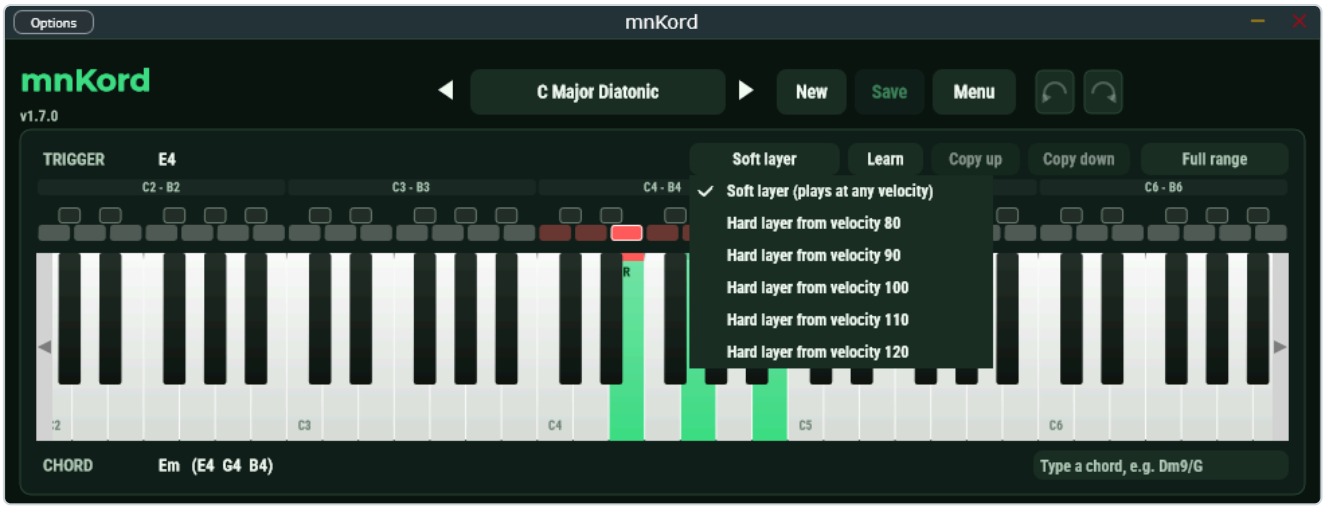
The scale button (it says **Full range** until you choose one) limits the keyboard to the notes of a scale (major, minor, pentatonic, ...) and fills the whole preset with triads or seventh chords of that scale.

Velocity layers

The layer menu in the TRIGGER row chooses which layer you are editing:

- **Soft layer:** plays at any velocity.
- **Hard layer from velocity 80 / 90 / 100 / 110 / 120:** a second chord for the same key, played instead when you hit the key at least that hard.

So one key can play a plain triad when played softly and a fuller chord when played hard.



The velocity layer menu

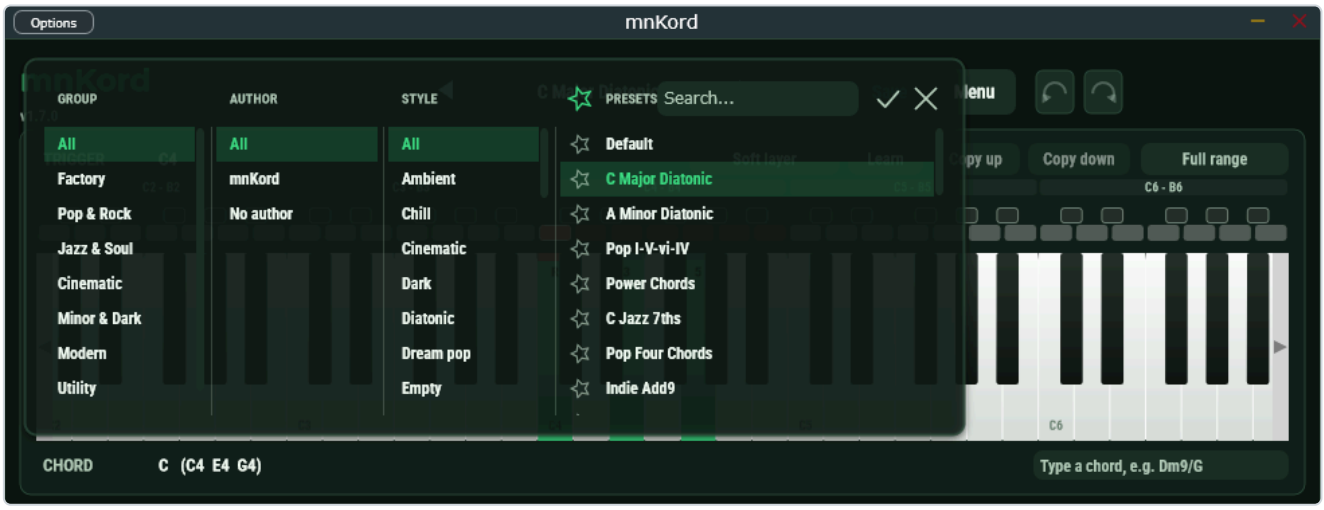
Undo

Every edit of the mappings can be undone and redone with the arrows, or **Ctrl+Z** / **Ctrl+Y**.

Presets

A preset is a set of key-to-chord mappings, with a name, a group, an author and style tags.

- **Factory presets** (about 30) are read only. Edit one and use **Save as** to keep your version.
- **Your presets** are saved as files and are shared by all projects and all copies of the plugin.
- Click the preset name to open the **browser**: columns for group, author and style, a search field and a star to mark favourites. Right-click a preset to load, duplicate, rename, show it in its folder or delete it (deleted files go to the recycle bin).
- **Save** writes the changes. When you leave a preset with unsaved changes, mnKord asks whether to save them. For a factory preset the choices are *Discard* or *Cancel* (use *Save as* first to keep them).
- **New** creates a preset. You can fill it with the chords of a scale (chord size, inversion, octave and the velocity of each chord role).
- The **Menu** button has *Save as*, *Revert to saved*, *Rename / edit info*, **Transpose** (the keys and chords together, or only the chords), *Import* (a preset or a whole bank file), *Export* and *Show in folder*.



The preset browser



The Menu button

Presets live in `Documents\MNAudio\mnKord`: the `Factory` folder is managed by the plugin, and the `User` folder holds your own presets. You can copy preset files in or out of it.

Projects

A DAW project stores the preset you were using **with its current edits**, not just a link to it. The project sounds the same on another computer even without your presets. If the stored preset differs from the one in the library (for example it was edited, or a later version changed a factory preset), it comes back marked as unsaved. **Revert to saved** loads the library's version, **Save as** keeps the project's version.

Program change

The host sees a fixed list of 128 programs: the presets, then empty slots named "-". Your DAW can switch presets with program changes and automation. User presets keep their numbers because they stay in the order you added them.

Standalone

The Standalone program (built from the source, not part of the installer) runs mnKord without a DAW. Open **Options** (top left) to choose the MIDI input and output and the audio device. Send mnKord's MIDI output to a synth, for example through a virtual MIDI cable.

Tips and problems

- **No sound:** mnKord makes no sound. Check that a synth is after it and that it receives MIDI.
- **A key plays nothing:** it has no chord in the current preset (it is dropped on purpose). Select the key and add notes.
- **Stuck notes:** transport stop and "all notes off" release the notes. If the synth still hangs a note, press the same key again.
- **The preset name has a dot:** it has unsaved changes. See *Projects* above.
- **Where is the plugin?** `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\MNAudio\mnKord.vst3`. Rescan the plugins in the DAW.

Keyboard

Key	Action
Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y	Undo / redo
Enter in the chord field	Apply the chord symbol
Esc in the chord field	Clear it

License

mnKord is free software under the GNU Affero General Public License v3.0 (see LICENSE). The bundled fonts keep their own licenses, in Resources/Fonts.